Important points to note about using the problem tree tool are:

- The quality of output will be determined by who is involved in the analysis and the skills of the facilitator. Involving stakeholder representatives with appropriate knowledge and skills is critical;
- A workshop environment involving groups of up to 25 people is an appropriate forum for developing problem tress, analyzing the results and then proposing next steps;
- It may be appropriate to undertake an number of separate problem tree analysis exercises with different stakeholder groups, to help determine different perspectives and how priorities vary;
- The process is as important as the product. The exercise should be treated as a learning experience for all those involved, and an opportunity for different views and interests to be expressed; and
- The product of the exercise (the problem tree) should provide a robust but simplified version of reality. If it is too complicated, it is likely to be less useful in providing direction to subsequent steps in the analysis. A problem tree cannot (and should not) contain or explain the complexities of every identifiable cause-effect relationship.

Once complete, the problem tree represents a summary picture of the *existing negative situation.*

In many respects the problem analysis is the most critical stage of project planning, as it then guides all subsequent analysis and decision-making on priorities.
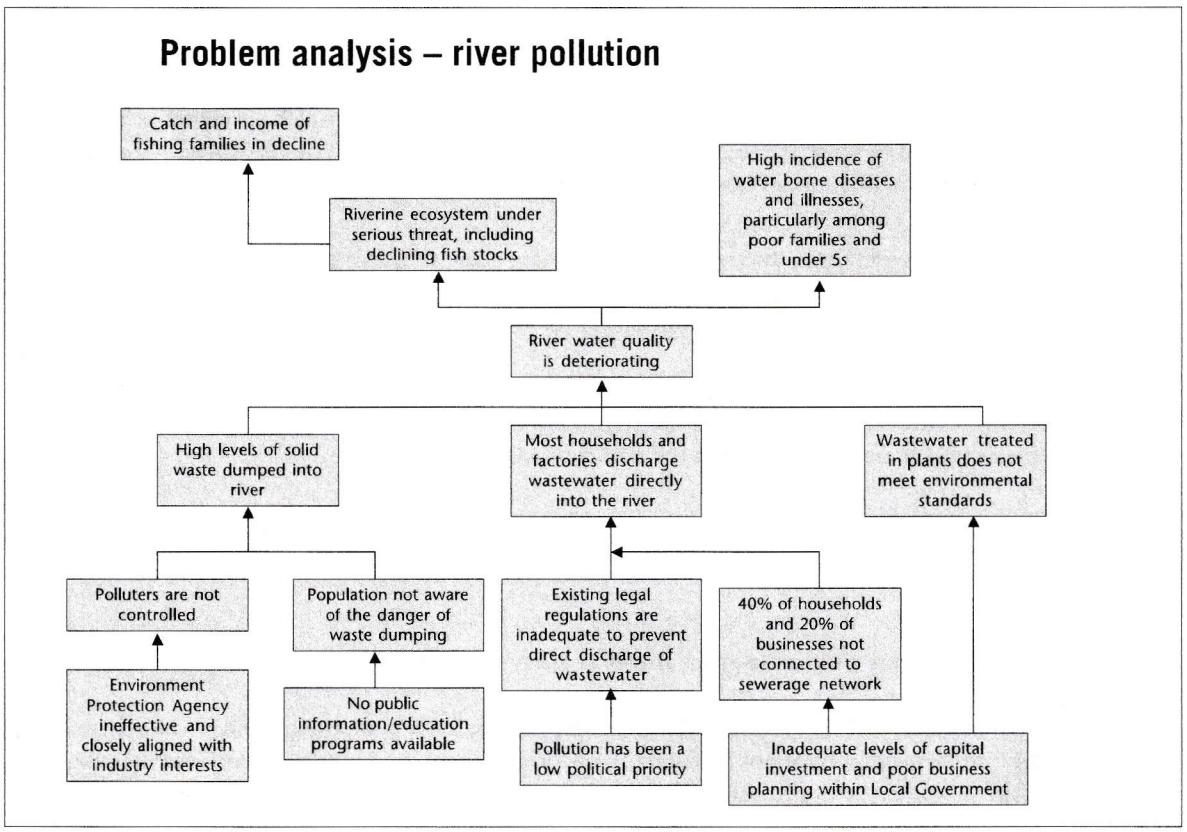
Figure 21 – Example of a problem tree